

SANJAY SONKAR



Ranked
99

Atul Sharma,
27, Lucknow

One of four brothers, he paid for his coaching classes by giving after-school tuitions

Wealth of Talent

With an ailing father who retired from the Uttar Pradesh electricity department and a family that largely depended on him for support, Atul Sharma could easily have put his dreams to rest. He didn't. After studying in a Hindi-medium school in Lucknow and then doing his graduation and postgraduation from Lucknow University in zoology, botany and chemistry as well as history respectively, he left for Delhi two years ago, paid for his UPSC coaching classes by giving tuitions, and was finally rewarded with a place in the top 100. It's been a constant balancing of the

books, as well as a reading of the books, paying Rs 40,000 every quarter for coaching in his subjects history and political science. Keeping body and soul together was not easy, with life in Delhi's Mukherji Nagar, at a rent of Rs 3,000 a month, requiring him to teach school students maths and chemistry. Yet he persisted, inspired by his mother's hopes. And his own ideals. Ask him why he wanted to become a civil servant and he says, "My aim is to serve the poor and the people in the rural areas, who by and large remain deprived of the development and progress in the country." *by Subhash Mishra*

"At times I thought of leaving Delhi and going back home. But my determination and will power won every time."

A Fine Aim

There couldn't be a better litmus test for Kiran Kaushal's determination to succeed than her stint as deputy collector in the Naxal-dominated Kanker district in the heart of Dandakaranya in Chhattisgarh where violence is as commonplace as a cup of morning tea. Not content with having got through the Chhattisgarh Public Service exam in 2005, the 28-year-old, undeterred either by her Hindi-medium schooling or her marriage, took the UPSC exam last year and came through with flying colours. Her father, who retired as assistant conservator of forests, was posted to all kinds of dots on the maps where good English-medium schools were hard to come by. Her education could have suffered. It didn't.

As Kaushal speaks in between

meetings in Raipur, one of them with Chief Minister Raman Singh, she seems unaffected by the overnight fame. The postgraduate in history says nothing can replace the old-fashioned work ethic. Juggling her duties as deputy collector in a difficult district with studies, she says teaming with her husband helped them focus. "One doesn't need to go to Delhi. You can prepare sitting right here," Kaushal says. "Analytical study helps more than wearing gemstones or performing pujas," she asserts, adding that even from small-town India, candidates can rise to the top provided they aim high enough and work methodically. "If you decide to be a *shikshakarmi* (teacher) or a patwari, you will end up becoming just that," she says. *by Ambreesh Mishra*

Ranked
3

Kiran Kaushal
28, Raipur

She took the UPSC exam in Hindi, and came third, way above her husband who clocked in at 707

VINAY SHARMA



"Analytical study helps more than wearing gemstones or performing pujas for success."